

£400 recruited five creators. None posted.

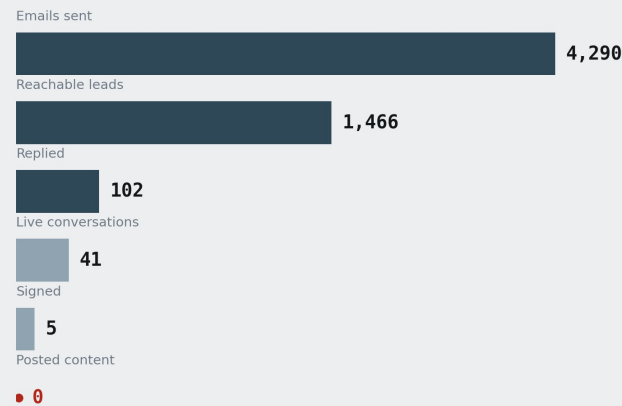
28 May – 29 June 2026. Summary view. Full reasoning and audit trail in the companion memo.

Final. Figures below are re-verified against source data. Live dashboard and repo linked in the footer.

I needed 10-20 creator partnerships to test whether UGC could move Stoke's subscriptions. Market rate for that was roughly **£6,000**. I had **£400**. Recruitment worked, five creators signed at £80 each. Activation didn't, zero posted. **The bottleneck sits after signup, and I know what caused it.**

SENT	LEADS	REPLIED	SIGNED	COST / SIGNUP	POSTED
4,290	1,466	102	5	£80	0

Where it dropped



The scale decision, day 8

Two metrics, two answers	Pre-scale window	
Raw reply rate favoured Campaign B , 3.38% against A's 2.36%. But roughly 60% of all replies were canned rate-card counters, a polite decline, not interest. Opportunities, live conversations flagged at the time, told a different story: A led 10 to B's 8, C's 4 , on near-identical pre-scale bases (~330 each).	LEADS	OPPS
Those counts are too close to call statistically significant on a base of 330. I knew that on the day. I read every flagged reply by hand to check the intent was real before scaling A on 4 June, eight days in . A judgment call the numbers supported, not one they proved.	A	10
	B	8
	C	4

What I know now

- 01 **No post-signup sequence existed.**
Onboarding was built, access and a discount code. Nothing was built to keep a signed creator moving toward actually filming. Solo bandwidth ran out after signup, and that's the specific, fixable gap.
- 02 **Habit transfer was the real bet, not the platform's rails.**
I already knew TikTok Shop's one-click purchase, not the commission structure alone, is why affiliates accept low pay. What was untested was whether that commission-only habit carries to a different platform.
- 03 **Supply was a harder ceiling than budget.**
~20% of sourced creators have an email at all, and under half of those are men, since TikTok Shop's volume categories skew female. Two cuts before economics ever entered it.

Not claiming: this settles the hypothesis. No paid-UGC video was ever run, so there's no counterfactual. Proof would have looked like eagerness, not just signups, and there was nothing built to sustain it, so weak interest and weak follow-through look identical in this data.